

NATIONAL INSTITUTES OF HEALTH STROKE SCALE (NIHSS)

Quantitative Measure of Stroke-Related Neurological Deficit

1. PATIENT IDENTIFICATION

Patient Name: _____

Unit / Ward / Bed: _____

Age / DOB: ____ / ____ / ____

Surgery / Diagnosis: _____

MRN / ID: _____

Date / Time: ____ / ____ / ____ : ____

1. CONSCIOUSNESS & GAZE

Parameter / Criterion	Options & Points
1a. LOC Responsiveness	☐ Alert (0) (0) ☐ Drowsy (1) (1) ☐ Stuporous (2) (2) ☐ Comatose (3) (3)
1b. LOC Questions (Month/Age)	☐ Both correct (0) (0) ☐ One correct (1) (1) ☐ Neither (2) (2)
1c. LOC Commands (Eyes/Fist)	☐ Both correct (0) (0) ☐ One correct (1) (1) ☐ Neither (2) (2)
2. Best Gaze	☐ Normal (0) (0) ☐ Partial gaze palsy (1) (1) ☐ Forced deviation (2) (2)
3. Visual Fields	☐ No loss (0) (0) ☐ Partial hemianopia (1) (1) ☐ Complete (2) (2) ☐ Bilateral (3) (3)
4. Facial Palsy	☐ Normal (0) (0) ☐ Minor palsy (1) (1) ☐ Partial palsy (2) (2) ☐ Complete (3) (3)

NIHSS Examination Rules: Administer scale items in exact order. Record performance as observed; do not coach or prompt patient. Scores ≥ 5 warrant urgent consideration for acute ischemic revascularization (IV thrombolysis / mechanical thrombectomy).

2. MOTOR, SENSORY & LANGUAGE

Parameter / Criterion	Options & Points
5. Motor Arm (Left & Right)	☐ No drift (0) (0) ☐ Drift (1) (1) ☐ Some effort (2) (2) ☐ No movement (4) (4)
6. Motor Leg (Left & Right)	☐ No drift (0) (0) ☐ Drift (1) (1) ☐ Some effort (2) (2) ☐ No movement (4) (4)
7. Limb Ataxia	☐ Absent (0) (0) ☐ In 1 limb (1) (1) ☐ In 2 limbs (2) (2)
8. Sensory Loss	☐ Normal (0) (0) ☐ Mild-moderate (1) (1) ☐ Severe loss (2) (2)
9. Best Language (Aphasia)	☐ No aphasia (0) (0) ☐ Mild-mod (1) (1) ☐ Severe (2) (2) ☐ Mute (3) (3)
10. Dysarthria	☐ Normal (0) (0) ☐ Mild-mod (1) (1) ☐ Severe / mute (2) (2)
11. Inattention (Neglect)	☐ No neglect (0) (0) ☐ Partial (1) (1) ☐ Profound (2) (2)

TOTAL SCORE: [] POINTS (Maximum: 42 points (0 to 42))

Assessor (RN / License #): _____

CLINICAL INTERPRETATION & RECOMMENDED NURSING ACTIONS

Minor Stroke (1 - 4 points)

Low functional deficit. Rapid secondary prevention and neuro monitoring.

Moderate Stroke (5 - 15 points)

Candidate for IV thrombolysis / endovascular thrombectomy if in window.

Moderate to Severe (16 - 20 points)

Substantial neurological deficit, high risk of hemorrhagic transformation.

Severe Stroke (21 - 42 points)

Severe stroke, high mortality risk. Neuro-ICU care, consider hemicraniectomy.

Registered Nurse (RN) Signature & Professional Stamp

Date & Time of Assessment